



Youth reboot: Arsene Wenger's India visit may help reboot how the country grooms its next football generation.

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to change that and encourage earlier participation.

Is there a long-term plan for youth coaching and talent scouting?

We currently have 16,696 AFC/AIFF-licensed coaches and 3,29,945 players registered under the CRS system. This season, we've organised 1,697 matches.

League participation has increased, but we still need more licensed coaches actively involved at the grassroots level. To address this, AIFF is identifying 500 coaches for retraining and deployment across India. The first phase was held in Bhubaneswar with 54 coaches.

Many states lack structured leagues and are affected by factionalism and court cases. What

is the AIFF doing to enforce league schedules and timely elections?

Sponsorship at the state level remains difficult. Without consistent financial backing, long-term planning suffers.

Each State/UT Association has its own constitution and operates under it. However, court cases are a major hurdle—whenever factions lose elections, they often resort to litigation.

Currently, there are nearly 275 sports-related court cases in which the Indian Olympic Association is involved.

At the start of your tenure, you prioritised grassroots development over hosting major events. Why did AIFF then bid for the 2031 AFC Asian Cup? Has the vision changed?

The vision hasn't changed. Multiple areas must grow together — grassroots development, international hosting, coach/referee education, and structural support. All

these components must move forward together to build a strong football.

The FIFA-AIFF TDS Academy has already made an impact at the U-15 level and in IWL-2. We plan to launch more such academies in the coming months.

Secondly, when we hosted the U-17 Women's World Cup, we lost our first match 0-8 against the USA. This clearly showed that our preparation was not adequate.

The AIFF's EC Meeting on November 16, 2022, stated: "AIFF decided to withdraw its bid (for Asian Cup 2027) due to infrastructure delays, a strong competing bid from Saudi Arabia, and concerns over team preparedness. A cost-benefit analysis showed a negative return, with an estimated investment of Rs. 5,000 crores needed for stadiums, facilities, and tournament operations. Therefore, a practical collective decision has been taken to bid for 2031 AFC Asian Cup with better preparation."